PROMISE & PRACTICE · DEEP DIVE · SOURCE ANALYSIS

The Ku Klux Klan — A House Divided

Studying Terror Honestly

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

WHAT I CAN DO TODAY I can read primary sources about The Ku Klux Klan — A House Divided, weigh who made each one and why, and use evidence to answer historical questions.

Directions. A secret group leaves conflicting evidence. Weigh who made each source, and why

THE SOURCES

THE IMAGE · 1872 — "Visit of the Ku-Klux"



"Visit of the Ku-Klux" — wood engraving, Harper's Weekly, 1872, public domain (Library of Congress).

SOURCE · CONGRESSIONAL TESTIMONY · 1871 — A witness under oath

> *"They said they were going to kill every … man that voted the Radical ticket. … They came to my house at night, armed and disguised …"*
> *— testimony before the Joint Select Committee on Klan violence, 1871. Public domain*

— testimony before the Joint Select Committee on Klan violence, 1871. Public domain.

YOUR WORK

QUESTION 1 STEP 1 · THE PURPOSE

Who were the Klan's main targets, and what was the political goal behind choosing them?

QUESTION 2 STEP 2 · TERROR AND THE BALLOT

How did Klan violence help white Democrats (“Redeemers”) win elections?

- ☐ A. by registering more voters
- ☐ B. by giving speeches
- ☐ C. by terrifying Black voters into staying home, shrinking the Republican vote
- ☐ D. by donating to campaigns

QUESTION 3 STEP 3 · SOURCING

Compare two kinds of sources: sworn testimony from victims, and the Klan's own denials. Which would you trust more to understand what the Klan did, and why? What does the Harper's image add?

QUESTION 4 STEP 4 · WHY IT MATTERS

In three or four sentences, explain how the Klan's campaign of terror was an attack not just on individuals but on democracy itself.

TEACHER ANSWER KEY — The Ku Klux Klan — A House Divided

QUESTION 1: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The Klan targeted..., in order to..."

QUESTION 2: **Correct — C. by terrifying Black voters into staying home, shrinking the Republican vote**

Right. By terrorizing Black voters into staying home, the Klan shrank the Republican vote — letting Democrats win and 'redeem' state governments for white rule.

QUESTION 3: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "I would trust ___ more because.... The image adds..."

QUESTION 4: Open response.

Look for a response along the lines of: "The Klan attacked democracy because..."